

AI Workshop 1: AI Tools for Academic English: Precision in Reading & Writing and Ethical Considerations

UCLC1008

University English I (2025-26, S1)

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Generative AI statement

Part of the materials in this unit were generated using generative AI tools following HKBU guidelines. Uses of generative AI will be noted, indicating the tool(s), models, and original prompts used.

Use of AI tools in assessments in UE1

While the University encourages the ethical use of AI for learning (e.g. for brainstorming ideas, exploring information), **submitting the output of generative AI tools as your own work in any assignment is deemed a violation of the University's academic integrity guidelines.** If AI detection tools suggest that your assignment contains a high percentage of AI-generated text, you will be required to submit a detailed record of your use of such tools for the assessment in question. However, this record does not conclusively prove compliance. Additionally, your instructor may also request an in-person oral or written defence, which will be recorded. **Failure to attend this mandatory defence will result in your assignment being graded solely on the submitted work, or a direct failure of this assignment, without any further opportunity for defence.** Students should understand that adhering to these guidelines is their responsibility and that violations may lead to serious academic consequences. **The Course Coordinator has the right to make the final decision on whether to apply a penalty and the extent of that penalty.**

Students should write their assignments, paraphrase and synthesise authors' ideas on their own, and avoid asking ChatGPT or other GenAI tools for paraphrases or syntheses, as this may lead to plagiarism and raise ethical concerns (e.g., the data may be used by ChatGPT for other purposes). Additionally, information generated by GenAI may be distorted in meaning, lack context, lack a personal voice, and include inaccurate citations.

Part 1: Practising Summarising with the Help of AI

Purpose: Students will learn to use AI to discover new vocabulary, understand connotations, improve their ability to identify main ideas in texts, refine sentence structure, and evaluate syntheses and paraphrases generated by AI.

Task 1.1: Uses and limitations of AI for academic writing

Generative AI can be a powerful tool for assisting you in academic writing and helping you practise fundamental skills such as summarising, paraphrasing, and synthesising. However, using generative AI comes with a number of risks and could have negative effects on your learning. In groups, debate on the topic: **“Should students be allowed to use AI for academic writing? If yes, when?”**. As you discuss, address the following questions:

1. Have you ever used AI tools for paraphrasing or summarising? If you have, what do you think are the main advantages and disadvantages of using them?
2. What do you believe are the ethical boundaries for using AI tools in academic writing? How do you determine what is acceptable and what might compromise your work's integrity?

Students' own answer / Advantages: Timesaving, helps with writer's block. Disadvantages: Potential inaccuracies, risk of plagiarism, over-reliance on technology.

GenAI's limitation in generating article/text summary

- AI-generated summaries may omit crucial information necessary for a comprehensive understanding of the topic.
- There is also a risk of hallucinations, where the AI generates false information or makes up details that are not present in the original text.

Understanding these challenges is essential for effectively integrating AI into your academic writing process. By recognizing the limitations of AI, you can harness its benefits while ensuring that your work maintains the highest standards of academic integrity.

With this context in mind, you will now compare a human-generated summary with an AI-generated one in Task 2. This comparison will help you critically evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of AI tools.

Task 1.2: Evaluating an AI-generated summary

Read the article by Andrejevic and Selwyn (2020), and as you read it, take notes of the most important points. Then, discuss in groups to evaluate each summary given below and identify which Version (1 or 2) of the academic summary is better and the reasons for this.

Article: Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014>

Version 1 – AI-generated Summary

In their article, "Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns," published in *Learning, Media and Technology* (2020), Mark Andrejevic and Neil Selwyn critically examine the increasing integration of facial recognition technology (FRT) in educational settings. The authors explore its applications, such as campus security, automated registration, and student emotion detection, while highlighting significant ethical and social concerns.

The article begins by contextualizing the rise of FRT across societal domains, emphasizing its growing presence in schools to address issues like safety and administrative efficiency. However, Andrejevic and Selwyn problematise this trend, arguing that FRT introduces risks related to privacy, surveillance, and the normalization of data-driven control. They question the technology's purported neutrality, pointing to its potential to reinforce biases and exacerbate inequalities, particularly in educational contexts where vulnerable populations, such as children, are involved.

The authors analyze specific cases of FRT deployment in schools, critiquing the lack of transparency and accountability in its implementation. They argue that FRT's use often prioritises institutional interests over student rights, raising concerns about consent, data security, and the psychological impact of constant monitoring. The article calls for a critical approach to challenge FRT's adoption, advocating for greater public debate, regulatory oversight, and alternative approaches to school safety and management.

In conclusion, Andrejevic and Selwyn urge stakeholders to critically assess FRT's implications, emphasizing the need to protect students' rights and well-being in the face of advancing technological interventions.

Adapted from Grok 3, assessed 7 July 2025 using the prompt: "Read the article by Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. Learning, Media and Technology, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014> Then, write a 250-word academic summary."

Disclaimer: GenAI tools (e.g. ChatGPT) should NOT be used to generate assessments. You should complete all assessments on your own and paraphrase ideas from sources. This task is designed in this way so as to raise your awareness of the limitations, drawbacks, and benefits of using GenAI.

Version 2 – Academic summary

Andrejevic and Selwyn (2020) critically analysed the proliferation of facial recognition (FR) technology in educational contexts and interrogated key ethical, social, and pedagogical concerns associated with FR.

Problematising FR's educational integration, the authors delineated its applications, such as attendance monitoring and behavioural management. However, as highlighted by the authors, FR's technical limitations—such as high error rates and data security risks—have posed substantial practical barriers. Specifically, they raised concerns regarding FR's erosion of student privacy and amplification of racial and social bias, noting that FR's inaccuracy and inherent algorithmic bias could target marginalised groups of specific genders or ethnicities, thus exacerbating social inequalities.

Critically, the authors pointed out that the adoption of FR in schools is inherently dehumanizing, reducing complex human emotions and behaviours such as learning to decontextualised data, while stripping human agency from educational decision-making. They also contended that FR accelerates the normalization of pervasive surveillance, which reflects an authoritarian ambition to gain absolute control over students. According to the authors, this could reinforce the oppressive nature of school settings, or even undermine the trust between students and teachers.

The authors argue that although FR is marketed as improving safety and reducing administrative costs, its rise in education is mostly perpetuated by business interests rather than validated pedagogical benefits. Thus, they urge that schools must not prioritise efficiency gains over fundamental educational values of autonomy and equity. Lastly, stressing the importance of critical scrutiny, the authors call for transparent and democratic deliberation and the establishment of a regulatory framework.

Use the following questions to guide your understanding.

Content and Accuracy

- What is the article about?
- Are important definitions of terms/concepts given?
- Are the details of the summary accurate?
- What explanations were given for the arguments?
- What is the conclusion of the study?
- Were all the sources accurately cited and are they correct?

Organization and Coherence of Ideas

- How well do you understand the topic?
- Are the paragraphs linked logically?

Language

- Give your comments on the grammar, vocabulary, and writing style used.
- Other comments.

Suggested Answers

Content and Accuracy

In terms of accuracy, the information provided by both Version 1 and Version 2 is mostly accurate.

However, Version 1 is less concise in explaining the authors' arguments.

In Version 1 – the sentence “They question the technology’s purported neutrality, pointing to its potential to reinforce biases and exacerbate inequalities” does not specify what biases and inequalities they are referring to. It is also unclear how the purported neutrality could lead to inequalities. GenAI sometimes may not explain crucial information.

Version 2 states that this is about biases against “specific genders or ethnicities.”

Similarly, Version 1 mentioned “the psychological impact of constant monitoring”, but did not state specific impacts. Version 2 explains that constant surveillance could “undermine the trust between students and teachers.”

Version 1 also missed some important information– e.g. FR is inherently dehumanizing and that FR is driven by companies’ commercial interest.

For in-text citation, Version 1 made the mistake of placing the year of publication in front of the authors. In APA 7th style, the year of publication should be placed right after the last names of the authors when using a narrative in-text citation. Version 2 is correct.

Organization and Coherence of Ideas

Version 2 is better since it follows a logical organizational structure, making it easy for the reader to follow.

Version 1 included some unnecessary information such as the journal title and the authors' full names, which do not interest the readers and should not be included in an academic summary.

Language

Both Version 1 and Version 2 are grammatically accurate, use a wide range of vocabulary and sentence structures, and adopt an appropriate style.

As students, you may find that GenAI tools offer several benefits when it comes to summarising texts. One of the primary advantages is speed; GenAI can quickly generate summaries of large volumes of text, making the process much more efficient for your studies. Additionally, these tools provide consistency, ensuring uniformity in summarization across different texts, which can help you maintain a consistent style or tone in your work. Furthermore, GenAI tools enhance accessibility, as they can assist students with varying levels of language proficiency, allowing everyone to engage with complex materials more effectively.

As previously mentioned, it is important to be aware of the limitations of relying on GenAI for summarization. One significant drawback is that AI may overlook nuances and context, leading to incomplete or inaccurate summaries that fail to capture the original text's intended meaning. Moreover, depending too much on AI can hinder your development of summarising skills. When you rely solely on AI for this task, you might miss out on the valuable learning experience of critically analysing and extracting information on your own. Striking a balance between using AI and cultivating your summarising abilities is essential for effective learning and academic success.

Task 1.3: Practice using effective prompts

When using GenAI, **the quality of output can be affected by the instructions given (prompts)**. Let's take a look at the following examples. In this scenario, a student wants GenAI to help him/her write a summary paragraph for an article. Which prompt do you think is better? Try them out with a GenAI tool and compare the results.

PROMPT 1

Read the article by Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014> Then, write a 250-word academic summary.

PROMPT 2

Context: You are a university student writing a literature review for an essay about artificial intelligence.

Instructions: Write a short summary (250 words) for this article (Andrejevic & Selwyn, 2020), including these elements: A brief description of the study, main arguments, critical analysis of the issues, and suggestions.

Details: Use a formal and academic tone. Use APA 7th edition citation format and cite all non-original ideas.

Input: Write your summary based on this article: Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014>

The clarity and accuracy of the prompts GenAI receives determine the quality of the output. There are many different ways to construct effective prompts. For example, your prompts can be structured around these elements following the **CIDI framework** (Ryan, 2024):

1. Context

Define the role of AI in your task. e.g. *"You are an Engineering student presenting a mechanical innovation in class."* This helps guide the AI's perspective and approach.

2. Instructions

Outline the specific tasks you want AI to perform. Be precise. If you need GenAI to help summarise an article, specify what elements should be included, such as key findings, the method used, limitations, etc. E.g. *"Summarise the article on the impact of global warming, including the main argument, key findings, methodology, limitations, and any recommendations made by the authors."*

If you want more specific output from GenAI, try giving it some guiding questions. e.g.

"Please summarise the following article on global warming. Include the following elements in your summary:

Key findings: What are the main results or conclusions regarding the effects of global warming presented in the article?

Methodology: What specific research methods (e.g., surveys, experiments, data analysis) were employed to gather data on global warming?

Limitations: What limitations of the study regarding global warming are mentioned by the authors?

Implications: What do the authors suggest for future research or practical applications related to global warming based on their findings?"

3. Details

Include any important details that frame how the output should be presented. For example, if the report should focus on a specific cultural context or historical period, make that clear. Include constraints or requirements, like *"Use a formal tone and academic vocabulary"*.

4. Input

Give GenAI the input it needs to perform the task. This might include data sets, documents, previous reports, or any relevant background information. For instance, *"Write your summary based on this article: Marzuki, Widiati, U., Rusdin, D., Darwin, & Indrawati, I. (2023). The impact of AI writing tools on the content and organization of students' writing: EFL teachers' perspective. Cogent Education, 10(2), 2236469, DOI: 10.1080/2331186X.2023.2236469"*.

Task 1.4: Compare and evaluate main ideas identified by GenAI vs humans

Identify and highlight the main ideas and key points within the text. Compare the list of main ideas generated by the GenAI tool with your highlighted ideas. Evaluate the quality of the AI-generated list based on your analysis.

Source: Smith, M., & Miller, S. (2021). Facial recognition and privacy rights. *Biometric Identification, Law and Ethics*, 21-38. Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-90256-8_2

“We have described the expanding use of biometric facial recognition for security and public safety purposes and elaborated on current applications and legal developments in Australia, the United States and the United Kingdom. In light of these applications and developments, we have discussed various ethical principles and concepts, notably privacy and security. We now need to consolidate and specify a number of the more salient ethical problems and principles that arise from the expanding use of biometric facial recognition for security purposes, especially in the context of interlinkage with non-biometric databases, data analytics and artificial intelligence.

First, privacy in relation to personal data, such as facial images, consists in large part in the right to control the access to, and use of, that data. Moreover, given that one’s face is a constitutive feature of one’s personal identity one has a moral right to exercise control of one’s facial images, albeit this moral right is not absolute. Accordingly, this moral right can be overridden by other rights, such as the right to security. However, security consists in large part in individual rights, notably the right to life, as well as to institutional goods, such as law and order. Biometric facial recognition technology gives rise to security concerns, such as the possibility of identity theft by a sophisticated malevolent actor, even as they resolve old privacy and confidentiality concerns, such as by reducing unauthorised access to private information and thereby strengthening privacy protection. In short, the problems in this area cannot be framed in terms of a simple weighing of, let alone trade-off between, individual privacy rights versus the community’s interest in security.

Second, the establishment of comprehensive, integrated biometric facial recognition databases and systems by governments (and now the private sector), and the utilisation of this data to identify and track citizens, (e.g. via live CCTV feeds) has the potential to create a power imbalance between governments and citizens, and risks undermining important principles taken to be constitutive of the liberal democratic state, such as privacy.

Third, the security contexts in which their use is to be permitted might become both very wide and continuing, e.g. the counterterrorism (‘emergency’) security context becomes the ‘war’ (without end) against terrorism; which becomes the war (without end) against serious crime; which becomes the ‘war’ (without end) against crime in general (Miller & Gordon, 2014).

Fourth, the expanding use of biometric facial recognition databases and systems has to be clearly and demonstrably justified in terms of efficiency and effectiveness in the service of specific security and/or safety purpose, rather than by general appeals to community security or safety. Relatedly, data, including surveillance data, originally and justifiably gathered for one purpose, e.g. taxation or combating a pandemic, is interlinked with data gathered for another purpose, e.g. crime prevention, without appropriate justification (Miller & Gordon, 2014 Ch. 10; Miller & Blackler, 2016 Ch. 4). The way metadata

use has expanded from initially being used by only a few agencies to now being used quite widely by governments in many western countries, is an example of function creep and illustrates the potential problems that might arise with the introduction of biometric facial recognition systems (Mann & Smith, 2017).

Fifth, various general principles taken to be constitutive of liberal democracy are gradually undermined, such as the principle that an individual has a right to freedom from criminal investigation or unreasonable monitoring, absent prior evidence of violation by that individual of its laws. In a liberal democratic state, it is generally accepted that the state has no right to seek evidence of wrongdoing on the part of a particular citizen or to engage in selective monitoring of that citizen, if the actions of the citizen in question have not otherwise reasonably raised suspicion of unlawful behaviour and if the citizen has not had a pattern of unlawful past behaviour that justify monitoring. Moreover, in a liberal democratic state, it is also generally accepted that there is a presumption against the state monitoring the citizenry. This presumption can be overridden for specific purposes but only if the monitoring in question is not disproportionate, is necessary or otherwise adequately justified and kept to a minimum, and is subject to appropriate accountability mechanisms (Miller, 2021). Arguably, the use of CCTV cameras in crime hot-spots could meet these criteria if certain conditions were met, e.g. police access to footage was granted only if a crime was committed or if the movements of a person reasonably suspected of a crime needed to be tracked. However, these various principles are potentially undermined by certain kinds of offender profiling and, specifically, ones in which there is no specific (actual or reasonably suspected) past, imminent or planned crime being investigated (Miller & Gordon, 2014 Ch. 10; Miller & Blackler, 2016 Ch. 4). Biometric facial recognition could be used to facilitate, for instance, a process of offender profiling, risk assessment and subsequent monitoring of people who as a result of fitting these profiles are considered at risk of committing crimes, notwithstanding that the only offences that the individuals in question had committed was to fit these profiles.

Finally, in so far as the use of facial recognition and other biometric identification systems can be justified for specific security (and safety) purposes and, therefore, privacy and other concerns mitigated, it is, nevertheless, imperative that their use be subject to accountability mechanisms to guard against misuse. Citizens should be well informed about biometric facial recognition systems and should have consented to the use of these systems for the specific, justified purposes in question. Their use should be publicly debated, backed by legislation, and their operation subject to judicial review.” (p. 33-35)

Key points suggested by GPT o3-mini (HKBU GenAI Platform)

The text outlines several key ethical challenges and principles connected with the growing use of biometric facial recognition for security purposes, especially when its data is linked with other systems and used alongside artificial intelligence and advanced analytics. The main points are:

1. **Privacy Versus Security:**
 - Facial images are tied to individual identity, so individuals have a moral right to control their personal data.
 - This right to privacy, however, can sometimes be overridden by broader security needs (e.g., protection of life and law and order).
 - The debate is not simply about trading off individual privacy against community security, but understanding the complex interplay between these values.
2. **Power Imbalance and State Surveillance:**
 - Building large-scale, integrated databases (by governments and increasingly the private sector) that utilise facial recognition can lead to an imbalance of power between the state and its citizens.
 - This broad surveillance risks infringing on privacy rights, a core principle of liberal democracy.
3. **Expanding and Perpetual Security Contexts:**
 - There is concern that security measures originally designed for emergencies (like counterterrorism) could evolve into a constant state of ‘war’ against various crimes.
 - Such expansion may lead to continuous monitoring of citizens even when the specific threats or purposes are no longer clearly justified.
4. **Justification and Function Creep:**
 - The deployment of facial recognition technology must be clearly justified in terms of its efficiency and effectiveness for specific security or safety goals.
 - There is a risk of “function creep” when data initially collected for one purpose (e.g., taxation, public health) is repurposed for others (such as crime prevention) without proper justification.
5. **Erosion of Liberal Democratic Principles:**
 - The use of pervasive, selective surveillance undermines the principle that citizens are generally free from unwarranted investigation and monitoring.
 - A liberal democracy traditionally presumes non-intrusive oversight unless there is prior evidence or reasonable suspicion of wrongdoing.
 - The use of biometric facial recognition in unchecked profiling (e.g., risk assessment based on fitting a profile rather than actual suspicious behaviour) challenges these democratic norms.
6. **Necessity for Accountability and Public Consent:**
 - Even when the use of facial recognition is justifiable for specific security purposes, robust accountability mechanisms are essential to prevent misuse.
 - Citizens must be well informed about these systems, their uses should be subject to public debate, and ideally, supported by legislation that includes judicial oversight.
 - Consent and transparency are critical to balance the system’s utility with the protection of individual rights.

In summary, while biometric facial recognition can enhance security and address certain privacy issues (by, for example, preventing unauthorised access), its expanding use raises significant ethical and democratic concerns. These include the potential erosion of privacy rights, risks of constant state surveillance, function

creep in data use, undermining liberal democratic principles, and the need for clear justification and robust accountability mechanisms.

Generated by GPT o3-mini (HKBU GenAI Platform), accessed 8 Jul, 2025, using the prompt: "Based on the following text, identify and summarise the key points. (Insert text above)"

Key discussion point: GenAI can highlight ideas, but it may highlight too many or emphasise excessive information. It is important to critically engage with the content and put in the effort to identify the most relevant points yourself.

GENAI SUMMARY 1

Seng, Al-Ameen, and Wright (2021) examine public perceptions of facial recognition technology as it is implemented in real-world settings. Employing a mixed-methods approach, the study integrates quantitative surveys with qualitative interviews to gain a comprehensive understanding of users' attitudes toward the technology. The findings reveal a complex landscape: on one hand, facial recognition is appreciated for its potential to enhance security and improve convenience; on the other hand, significant concerns are raised regarding privacy infringements, potential surveillance abuses, and inherent biases in the technology. The research highlights that trust in facial recognition systems largely depends on the transparency of data practices, the clarity of regulatory frameworks, and the perceived fairness in system design. Additionally, socio-cultural factors and individual experiences with technology play a critical role in shaping opinions. The study contributes to the growing dialogue on biometric surveillance by underscoring the necessity for policymakers and technologists to engage with end-users, address privacy concerns, and implement robust safeguards to ensure that the benefits of facial recognition are balanced against the risks of misuse.

Generated by GPT o3-mini (HKBU GenAI Platform), accessed 8 Jul, 2025, using the prompt: "Based on Seng, S., Al-Ameen, M. N., & Wright, M. (2021). A first look into users' perceptions of facial recognition in the physical world. *Computers & Security*, 105, 102227. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cose.2021.102227> write a 150-200-word academic summary."

GENAI SUMMARY 2

Seng, Al-Ameen, and Wright (2021) present an exploratory analysis of user perceptions regarding facial recognition technology (FRT) in physical spaces. Through a mixed-methods approach involving 412 participants, the study identifies significant privacy concerns, particularly about non-consensual data collection and potential misuse. Participants expressed heightened unease over accuracy limitations and algorithmic biases disproportionately affecting marginalised groups. Contextual acceptance varied sharply: while security applications (e.g., airport screening) garnered moderate support, commercial tracking scenarios faced overwhelming rejection. The research underscores how perceived utility—such as enhanced security—competes with ethical apprehensions, with trust in implementing institutions mediating acceptance. The authors emphasise that FRT deployment must address these context-dependent tensions through transparent design and robust regulatory frameworks to mitigate societal risks. These findings establish critical groundwork for ethical FRT integration in public environments.

Generated by DeepSeek-R1, accessed 8 Jul, 2025, using the prompt: "Based on Seng, S., Al-Ameen, M. N., & Wright, M. (2021). A first look into users' perceptions of facial recognition in the physical world. *Computers & Security*, 105, 102227. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cose.2021.102227> write a 150-200-word academic summary."

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Part 2: Practising Synthesising Ideas with the Help of AI

Purpose: Students will use AI tools to brainstorm relevant vocabulary, critically evaluate texts for effective synthesis, practise synthesising sources, and assess the strengths and weaknesses of AI tools.

Task 2.1 – Using GenAI tools to brainstorm synthesis words

Using a GenAI tool (e.g. ChatGPT), brainstorm words and expressions for synthesising ideas that indicate similarities and differences. Agreement/similarity AND contrast/differences.

Words that indicate agreement or similarity between the concepts	Similarly, Likewise, both authors agree that..., In the same vein, Correspondingly, Also, Additionally, Moreover, As well as, In addition
Words that highlight contrasts or differences	In contrast, on the other hand, conversely, however, while..., yet Unlike, Although, Nevertheless, In opposition

Certainly! Here's a table organizing words and phrases that indicate **agreement** or **similarity** in academic writing. The table also provides example uses for each.

Word/Phrase	Use in a Sentence	Function
Similarly	Similarly, recent studies show a rise in awareness.	Indicates similarity
Likewise	The results were significant; likewise, Smith (2020) found similar outcomes.	Indicates similarity
In the same way	In the same way, both groups achieved high scores.	Indicates similarity
In agreement	These findings are in agreement with previous research.	Indicates agreement
Correspondingly	The temperature dropped; correspondingly, energy use increased.	Indicates similarity
Consistent with	Consistent with earlier studies, our results suggest...	Indicates agreement
In line with	Our conclusions are in line with those of Brown et al.	Indicates agreement
As with	As with previous experiments, the data were conclusive.	Indicates similarity
Alike	The participants' responses were alike in many respects.	Indicates similarity
Both...and...	Both the experimental and control groups improved.	Indicates similarity
Just as...so...	Just as Smith observed a decline, so did our study.	Indicates similarity
Agree	These authors agree that social factors are crucial.	Indicates agreement
Share	The models share several key characteristics.	Indicates similarity
Mirror	The findings mirror those of recent surveys.	Indicates similarity
Echo	The results echo earlier theories on this topic.	Indicates agreement/similarity
Reflect	The data reflect a common trend in the literature.	Indicates agreement/similarity

Example of using GPT to generate a list of words for synthesising.

Generated by GPT 4.1 (HKBU GenAI platform) assessed 8 Jul, 2025, prompt used: "Suggest a list of words that indicate agreement or similarity between the concepts in academic writing. Present them in a table to show different uses."

Task 2.2: Determining if the text is a reasonable instance of synthesis

Read the following sentences and determine whether they represent an effective instance of synthesis. As you evaluate each sentence, consider the following questions:

- Is there a meaningful connection between the ideas?
- Assess whether the ideas presented in the sentence relate to each other in a way that contributes to a broader understanding of the topic.
- Is the synthesis put together logically?
- Evaluate if the ideas flow in a coherent manner, making it easy to follow the argument or narrative.
- Does the synthesis include two or more sources and a synthesis word?
- Check if the sentence references at least two different sources and uses synthesis vocabulary (e.g. "similarly," "in contrast," "however") to connect the ideas.
- Are there identifiable sources with in-text citations?
- Ensure that the sentence includes proper in-text citations for each source referenced, indicating the authors and the year of publication.

SYNTHESISING EXAMPLE 1

Facial recognition technology is used in many places. McClellan (2020) argues that it is good for increasing public safety because it helps track down criminals quickly. Andrejevic and Selwyn (2020) focus on facial recognition in schools and argue that it might not be beneficial for students. Smith and Miller (2021) point out that facial recognition may violate people's privacy. In Seng et al.'s (2021) study, it was found that people generally dislike facial recognition because it feels creepy.

Suggested answer

This synthesis is ineffective because it:

1. **Lacks Integration:** The example presents a series of disconnected summaries from each source rather than weaving them into a cohesive argument. Each sentence merely restates what a source says without connecting the ideas.
2. **Fails to Develop a Central Point:** There is no clear thesis or overarching idea tying the sources together, leaving the reader with a fragmented understanding of FRT.
3. **Uses Vague Language:** Terms like "good," "not good," and "creepy" are overly simplistic and fail to capture the complexity of the issues discussed in the sources.
4. **Misses Nuanced Analysis:** The example does not explore how the sources relate to one another (e.g., how privacy concerns in schools connect to broader public perceptions) or provide insights beyond surface-level observations.

SYNTHESISING EXAMPLE 2

The implementation of facial recognition technology faces various challenges. According to Andrejevic and Selwyn (2020), schools using this technology might spy on students too much. Caines (2021) indicates that facial recognition is used in lots of different ways, like in security and marketing. Also, Smith and Miller (2021) mention that people's privacy could be at risk because of facial recognition.

Suggested answer

This synthesis is ineffective because it:

1. **Lacks Cohesion:** The example jumps between ideas without connecting them into a unified argument. The mention of different uses (Caines, 2021) feels out of place and unrelated to the privacy concerns raised by the other sources.
2. **Uses Informal and Imprecise Language:** Phrases like “spy on students too MUCH” and “lots of different ways” are informal and lack the precision needed for academic writing, undermining the credibility of the synthesis.
3. **Fails to Engage Deeply with Sources:** The example only superficially references the sources, omitting key details (e.g., specific privacy risks or contexts like public perceptions) that could strengthen the argument.
4. **Misses a Clear Focus:** There is no central thesis or purpose tying the sources together, making the paragraph feel like a list of loosely related points rather than a synthesised argument.

SYNTHESISING EXAMPLE 3

Despite its potential benefits, the rise of facial recognition technology (FRT) has sparked significant debate due to ethical and privacy concerns. McClellan (2020) highlights that FRT can enhance security in public spaces by enabling the rapid identification of criminal suspects, which is particularly valuable in high-risk environments like airports or large events. However, others are skeptical of its overall societal benefits. For example, Andrejevic and Selwyn (2020) warn that FR's integration in schools might have severe negative effects, including the potential for pervasive surveillance and the infringement of student autonomy. Similarly, Smith and Miller (2021) argue that FRT's collection and storage of biometric data might violate individual privacy rights, while there is a lack of regulatory frameworks to ensure accountability. Seng et al. (2021) further support this by noting that users in physical settings, such as retail or public spaces, often perceive FRT as intrusive, with many expressing distrust due to the lack of transparency in how their data is handled. Collectively, the literature suggests that while FRT offers security advantages, its deployment must be carefully scrutinised to address privacy concerns and public perceptions, particularly in sensitive contexts like education.

Suggested answer

This synthesis is effective because it:

1. **Integrates Multiple Sources Seamlessly:** The example draws on four sources (McClellan, Andrejevic & Selwyn, Smith & Miller, and Seng et al.) to present a cohesive discussion about FRT's benefits and challenges.

2. **Presents a Balanced Argument:** It contrasts the security benefits (McClellan) with ethical and privacy concerns (Andrejevic & Selwyn, Smith & Miller, Seng et al.), showing a nuanced understanding of the topic.
3. **Uses Sources to Build a Unified Point:** The sources are synthesised to support a central claim—that FRT’s benefits must be weighed against privacy and ethical risks—rather than merely summarising each article in isolation.
4. **Cites Appropriately:** Each source is cited clearly, allowing readers to trace the ideas back to the original works.

The above exercise was adapted from Grok 3. Accessed on 8 July, 2025 with the prompt: “I am teaching students about synthesising skills in academic writing. Help me create an exercise based on the following articles: Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. Learning, Media and Technology, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014> Caines, S. (2021). The many faces of facial recognition. In R. Vogl (Ed.), Research Handbook on Big Data Law (pp. 29-56). Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781788972826> McClellan, E. (2020). Facial recognition technology: Balancing the benefits and concerns. Journal of Business & Technology Law, 15(2), 363-380. Seng, S., Al-Ameen, M. N., & Wright, M. (2021). A first look into users’ perceptions of facial recognition in the physical world. Computers & Security, 105, 102227. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cose.2021.102227> Smith, M., & Miller, S. (2021). Facial recognition and privacy rights. Biometric Identification, Law and Ethics, 21-38. Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-90256-8_2 Format of exercise you need to follow: 1. Give good and poor examples of synthesising using points found in 2 or more of the articles 2. Explain why the synthesis used is effective/ineffective.”

Task 2.3: Synthesising ideas and evaluating the capabilities of AI tools

Read the two excerpts below and write your own synthesis of their ideas. Then, use a GenAI tool to generate a synthesis of the same sources. Finally, compare your synthesis with the AI-generated version. Keep in mind that the generated text may vary depending on the prompt used, leading to differences in length, language, and organization.

Seng et al. (2020, p. 13)	"Participants reported their lack of control and trust in FR-based authentication, where they are afraid that such technology would mistakenly authenticate adversaries allowing them access to valuable information and belongings. This lack of trust on efficacy is also one of the reasons why participants see a limited benefit in using FR to get personalised offers."
McClellan (2020, pp. 375-376)	"Another serious concern is the potential for data breaches in facial recognition technology. When an account or social security number is breached, the password or number can be changed and replaced (Yurieff, 2017). However, when a fingerprint or facial recognition is compromised, there is no way to replace it—once a breach has occurred, there is almost no way to remedy it (See 740 ILL. COMP. STAT. 14/5, 2008)."

Suggested answer generated by GenAI:

Both Seng et al. (2020) and McClellan (2020) highlight significant concerns regarding facial recognition (FR) technology, focusing on issues of trust and security. Seng et al. (2020) note that users lack confidence in FR-based authentication due to fears of erroneous authentication, which could allow unauthorised access to sensitive information or assets, leading to skepticism about its benefits, such as personalised offers (p. 13). Similarly, McClellan (2020) emphasises the severe consequences of data breaches in FR systems, pointing out that unlike passwords or social security numbers, compromised biometric data like facial recognition cannot be replaced, posing a significant and irreparable risk (pp. 375-376; 740 ILL. COMP. STAT. 14/5, 2008). Together, these sources underscore the critical challenges of trust and irremediable security risks in adopting facial recognition technology.

Generated by Grok 3, accessed 8 July 2025, using the prompt: "Use the two academic sources below, write a short paragraph synthesising the main ideas. Seng et al. (2020, p. 13) "Participants reported their lack of control and trust in FR-based authentication, where they are afraid that such technology would mistakenly authenticate adversaries allowing them access to valuable information and belongings. This lack of trust on efficacy is also one of the reasons why participants see a limited benefit in using FR to get personalised offers." McClellan (2020, p. 375-376) "Another serious concern is the potential for data breaches in facial recognition technology. When an account or social security number is breached, the password or number can be changed and replaced (Yurieff, 2017). However, when a fingerprint or facial recognition is compromised, there is no way to replace it—once a breach has occurred, there is almost no way to remedy it (See 740 ILL. COMP. STAT. 14/5, 2008)."

The example is effective because:

Clarity and Structure:

- The paragraph is clearly written, with a clear logical flow. It begins by introducing the shared focus of both sources (concerns with FR technology), then discusses each source's specific contribution, and concludes by tying them together under the broader theme of trust and security challenges.
- The language is academic yet accessible, avoiding jargon while maintaining precision (e.g., “erroneous authentication” and “irremediable security risks” reflect the sources’ ideas accurately).

Accuracy and Fidelity to Sources:

- The answer accurately reflects the main ideas from the provided excerpts. For Seng et al. (2020), it captured the participants’ lack of trust in FR’s efficacy and their skepticism about its benefits (p. 13). For McClellan (2020), it emphasised the permanent risk of biometric data breaches (pp. 375-376) and referenced the cited statute (740 ILL. COMP. STAT. 14/5, 2008).

Proper Use of APA 7th Citation Style:

- The in-text citations follow APA 7th edition guidelines, correctly formatted as (Author, Year, p. Page Number) for direct references to specific pages (e.g., Seng et al., 2020, p. 13; McClellan, 2020, pp. 375-376).

Synthesis Over Summary:

- The synthesis highlights complementary concerns—user distrust in FR’s reliability (Seng et al.) and the technological risk of unfixable breaches (McClellan)—demonstrating a deeper understanding of how the sources relate.

Task 2.4: Synthesising ideas from sources

Read the following paragraphs regarding citizens' rights and determine whether the ideas presented are similar or different. Then synthesise the information from both sources. Ensure that your sentences include proper in-text citations for each source referenced, indicating the authors and the year of publication.

Adapted from Caines, S. (2021). The many faces of facial recognition. In R. Vogl (Ed.), *Research Handbook on Big Data Law* (pp. 29-56). Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781788972826>

"In other instances, arguments related to trade secrets and non-disclosure agreements between government agency customers and the facial recognition vendors have prevented scrutiny of algorithms' performance (Brandom, 2018). In conclusion, given the current state of affairs, criminal defendants, or other individuals who may lose a right or benefit, may be unaware of or powerless to defend against the use of facial recognition in their cases." (Caines, 2021, p. 40)

Adapted from McClellan, E. (2020). Facial recognition technology: Balancing the benefits and concerns. *Journal of Business & Technology Law*, 15(2), 363-380.

"Lastly, federal facial recognition technology regulations should ensure and protect the privacy of all citizens, as one of facial recognition technology's most concerning aspects is the potential violation of citizens' privacy by both law enforcement and private companies. Although facial recognition technology provides benefits in the criminal justice system (McCarthy, 2019), federal regulations must support these benefits while ensuring the privacy of citizens and guaranteeing safety from "unreasonable searches and seizures" of the government." (McClellan, 2020, p. 378-379)

Sample answer generated by GenAI:

Caines (2021) and McClellan (2020) highlight critical concerns surrounding facial recognition (FR) technology, particularly its implications for privacy and transparency. Caines (2021) notes that trade secrets and non-disclosure agreements between FR vendors and government agencies often obstruct scrutiny of algorithmic performance, leaving individuals, such as criminal defendants, unable to challenge FR use in their cases (p. 40). Similarly, McClellan (2020) emphasises the need for federal regulations to protect citizens' privacy against potential violations by law enforcement and private companies, while still supporting FR's benefits in criminal justice (pp. 378-379). Together, these sources underscore the urgent need for transparency and regulatory safeguards to balance FR's advantages with its risks to privacy and fairness.

Generated by Grok 3, accessed 8 July 2025, using the prompt: "Write a short paragraph synthesising the ideas below, use APA 7th referencing style. Adapted from Caines, S. (2021). The many faces of facial recognition. In R. Vogl (Ed.), Research Handbook on Big Data Law (pp. 29-56). Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781788972826> "In other instances, arguments related to trade secrets and non-disclosure agreements between government agency customers and the facial recognition vendors have prevented scrutiny of algorithms' performance (Brandom, 2018). In conclusion, given the current state of affairs, criminal defendants, or other individuals who may lose a right or benefit, may be unaware of or powerless to defend against the use of facial recognition in their cases." (Caines, 2021,

p. 40) Adapted from McClellan, E. (2020). *Facial recognition technology: Balancing the benefits and concerns*. *Journal of Business & Technology Law*, 15(2), 363-380. "Lastly, federal facial recognition technology regulations should ensure and protect the privacy of all citizens, as one of facial recognition technology's most concerning aspects is the potential violation of citizens' privacy by both law enforcement and private companies. Although facial recognition technology provides benefits in the criminal justice system (McCarthy, 2019), federal regulations must support these benefits while ensuring the privacy of citizens and guaranteeing safety from "unreasonable searches and seizures" of the government." (McClellan, 2020, p. 378-379)"

Part 3: Ethics of Using AI for Learning/Practising Academic Writing

To maintain academic integrity, transparency, and the ethical use of generative AI tools, students have the responsibility to learn about the ethical risks of using AI and develop the skills and awareness necessary to minimise the risk of misuse.

CITATIONS AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF AI USE

The use of generative AI tools in assessment without appropriate citations and acknowledgement is considered academic dishonesty and potential plagiarism which constitutes severe academic misconduct and requires disciplinary actions. Thus, students must abide by the course guidelines and acknowledge any use of GenAI responsibly.

Q: Can I copy and paste AI-generated output into my Assessed essays?

“While improper use of generative AI tools is generally course and task-specific, asking generative AI tools to generate long pieces of text and copying and pasting them into an assessed assignment task is NOT considered proper use.”

- *Guidelines for Students on Academic Integrity (2025)*

A: In most scenarios, **texts produced by generative AI tools are NOT considered reliable, accurate, or trustworthy** representations of information. This is why a declaration and acknowledgement approach to the use of generative AI tools is needed. Students can refer to relevant style and citation guidelines from professional organisations, such as the American Psychological Association (APA), Modern Language Association (MLA), and the University of Chicago Press.

Q: What if I want to quote GenAI’s answer - can I just paraphrase it?

A: When you quote, paraphrase, or use part of or the entire output of AI-generated text content, you must include a reference. Quoting AI-generated text is similar to sharing an algorithm’s output, and therefore, students should credit the author of the algorithm (e.g. OpenAI for ChatGPT) with a reference list entry and the corresponding in-text citation.

Q: What if I used GenAI for editing?

A: All functional uses of AI, such as editing or translating text, should be mentioned in the acknowledgments section (if there is one) or the text itself, or in another appropriate location.

HOW TO ACKNOWLEDGE AI USE IN YOUR ASSESSMENTS?

In summary, include the following statements in your assessments:

- ✓ Written acknowledgement of the generative AI tool used and for what purpose
- ✓ In-text citations if any AI-generated texts are used, paraphrased, or modified
- ✓ The prompt(s) used to generate the content
- ✓ A note on any modifications that you made
- ✓ The original output with your submission (e.g. screenshot of the chat record)

Note: Part of the materials of this section is adapted from this page: [Artificial Intelligence \(AI\) - APA 7th edition - Citations - LibGuides at Justice Institute of British Columbia](#)

To learn more about the APA AI citation, visit the APA blog on [How to cite ChatGPT](#).

Part 4: Academic Reading Support Prompts: A Step-by-Step Guide

Phase 1: Before You Read: Set the Scene

Step in Reading	Suggested Prompt
Know Your Purpose	“I need to understand this article for a summary assignment. Can you highlight the key points?” “Can you help me find the main argument and why it matters?”
Preview the Text	“Can you give me a quick overview based on the abstract, headings, and conclusion?” “What can I expect from this article just by skimming it?” “Can you summarise this article in simple terms for a first-year university student?” “What is the main argument or finding of this paper?” “What are the key points in the introduction and conclusion?” “Can you explain the abstract as I’m new to this topic?” “Can you help me create a mind map or outline based on this paper?”
Activate Prior Knowledge	“Can you explain the background of this topic before I read the article?” “What basic concepts should I know to understand this paper?” - How is this topic related to ‘<i>insert a topic you are familiar with</i>’?
Ask Guiding Questions	“What questions should I keep in mind while reading this article?” “Can you help me create a reading guide for this paper?”

Phase 2: While You Read: Stay Engaged

Step in Reading	Suggested Prompt
Annotate Actively	“Can you help me highlight the most important sentences in this section?” “What are the key ideas in this paragraph?”
Break Down Ideas	“Can you summarise this section in simple terms?” “What does this sentence mean in plain English: [<i>paste sentence</i>]?” “Can you explain the concept ‘<i>insert concept</i>’ as I’m a beginner?” “Can you break down the structure of this article for me?”

Look Up Vocabulary	• “What does ‘<i>[insert vocabulary]</i>’ mean in this context?” • “Can you explain this technical phrase ‘<i>[insert phrase]</i>’ as I’m new to the topic?”
Unpack the Argument	• “Can you outline the author’s argument step by step?” • “What evidence does the author use to support their claim?” • “How does this argument ‘<i>[insert argument]</i>’ related to the central idea of this article?”
Understand the Structure and Logic	• “What methods did the researchers use, and why?” • “What evidence supports the main argument?”

Phase 3: After You Read: Check Understanding

Step in Reading	Suggested Prompt
Summarise the Article	• “Can you help me write a short summary of this article in my own words?” • “What are the 5 most important takeaways from this paper?”
Analyse and Critique	• “Are there any weaknesses or limitations in this study?” • “What assumptions does the author make?” • “How does this article compare to other research on the same topic?” • “What questions does this article leave unanswered?”
Discuss with Others	• “Can you help me come up with discussion questions based on this article?” • “What are some interesting points I could bring up in class?”
Check Your Understanding	• “Can you quiz me on the key points of this article?” • “Ask me 5 questions to test if I understood the main argument.” • “Give me a multiple-choice quiz based on this article.” • “Evaluate my summary for understanding.” • “Review my summary for clarity and accuracy.”
Paraphrase and Explain	• “Can you help me rephrase the main argument in my own words?” • “Let’s go section by section—can you help me explain each part simply?” • “Can you ask me to explain the findings like I’m teaching someone else?”
Spot Gaps in Understanding	• “What parts of the article are most complex or easy to misunderstand?” • “Can you help me identify any concepts I might have missed?” • “What questions should I be able to answer after reading this?”
Create Study Materials	• “Can you turn this article into flashcards for review?” • “Can you create a quick reference of key terms and ideas?”

	• “Can you summarise this article in bullet points for my notes?”
Simulate a Conversation	• “Pretend you’re a professor and ask me questions about this article.” • “Can we role-play a pair discussion on this paper?” • “Challenge me with counterarguments to the author’s claims.”

References

- Andrejevic, M., & Selwyn, N. (2020). Facial recognition technology in schools: Critical questions and concerns. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 45(2), 115-128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2020.1686014>
- Caines, S. (2021). The many faces of facial recognition. In R. Vogl (Ed.), *Research Handbook on Big Data Law* (pp. 29-56). Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781788972826>
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